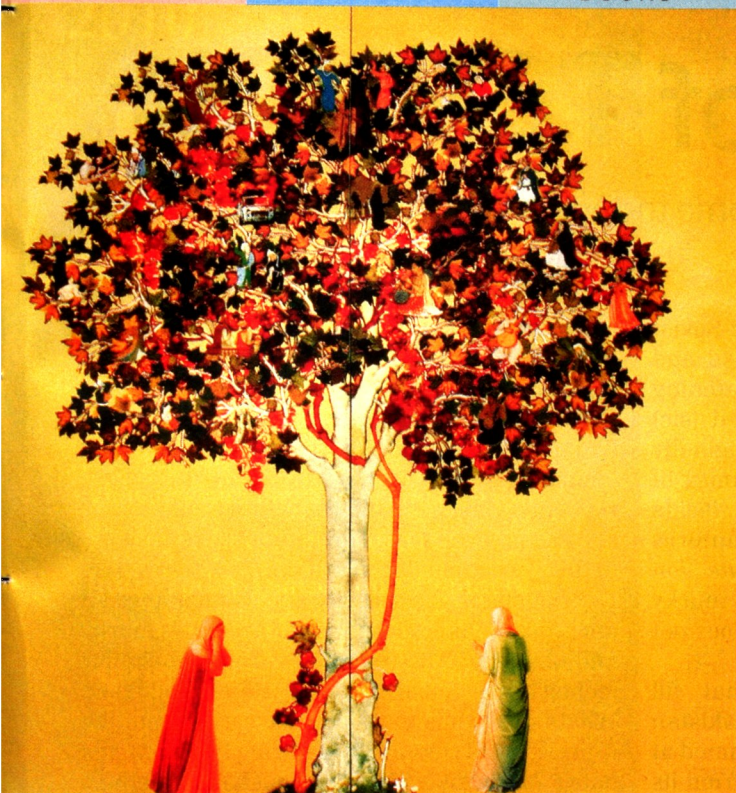




water from a truck. Or even 53-year-old Pushpamala N.'s self centrality, from being the subject of a Raja Ravi Varma painting to a native woman of south India in a series called *The Ethnographic Types*. The variety of forms is so mind-boggling that it actually prompted a German art critic to wonder whether artists had stopped painting altogether in India.

But clearly a new discourse is emerging among artists in India, which allows them to literally take flights of fancy—in the case of the MS University-trained and Vadodara based 51-year-old Nataraj Sharma, *Air Show* is a gigantic scaffolding which has planes soaring to the sky—forcing the West to start dumping its Orientalist stereotypes. The Essl Museum exhibition comes from the Mori Art Museum in Tokyo and stemmed from a conversation Essl and his wife Agnes had with Indian collectors Lekha Poddar and her son Anupam in 2006. “I was astounded to learn of the range of contemporary art, its power and its freshness and when I found out that there was an exhibition in Tokyo, I tied up with

**JITISH KALLAT, 35,
AUTOSAURUS
TRIPOUS, A
RETORT TO
VIOLENCE**



it,” says Essl who is chairman of Austria’s leading operator of DIY hardware stores, Baumax AG, with 150 stores across Europe. Art is his passion and as he took 11 awestruck Indian artists on a tour of his spotlessly clean storehouse, pulling out frame upon frame of Antoni Tapes and Maria Lassnig, it was clear he has invested his money for pure passion not pelf.

And next year he plans India Awakens: Under the Banyan Tree, an exhibition of 35 next generation Indian artists whom he has collected over the years. But even the group of 11 artists travelling together in Vienna span three generations, from the 72-year-old Sheikh, who studied both at the MS University and London’s Royal College of Art to the 30-year-old former ad executive, trained at the National Institute of Design and fond of sporting yellow



**TUSHAR JOAG, 43,
THE UNICELL MAN
HAS FAUX URBAN
SOLUTIONS**

**GULAMMOHAMMED
SHEIKH, 72,
SPEAKING TREE
THAT UNITES FAITH**

shoes, Sumir Tagra. Indeed the camaraderie between the artists is clearly proof that though the Government may have forsaken artists, the community has not. Whether it was Sheikh pulling Kallat’s leg about being able to buy a minor vineyard near Vienna or Joag discussing Austria’s most recent, lamentable export, Bruno, with Sharma, they did relate to each other at an intimate level.

Indeed as Jitish Kallat put it, perhaps there will be a time soon where nations will be obliterated by innovations, where borders will become blurred by the translationality of its people. So though Indian art may have caught the western world’s attention because of the country’s growing economy, it will demand an understanding from the world for its unbridled questioning of its history and its voracious appetite for the future. ■